

BRIEF ENCOUNTER

David Lean, 1945

British director David Lean's early masterpiece is a simple story, based on a Noel Coward play, and very different from the epics, such as *Lawrence of Arabia*, for which he later became better known. Housewife Laura (Celia Johnson) and Doctor Alec (Trevor Howard) meet at a train station café. Tempted into an adulterous affair, they pull back because both are, at heart, deeply decent people. The shadowy light of the station, and the music of Rachmaninoff's *Piano Concerto No. 2*, give emotional weight to Johnson's and Howard's understated performances.

MURDERERS AMONG US

Wolfgang Staudte, 1946

Murderers Among Us was one of the first German movies made after World War II, completed in the Soviet-occupied sector, and reflecting Germany's struggle to come to terms with its past. Shot in the ruins of Berlin, it tells the story of a military surgeon who returns home to find his home destroyed. He moves in with a young woman who survived the concentration camps. The surgeon plans to kill his captain, who murdered Polish civilians in the war, but the woman persuades him to let the man go to trial.

BUILD MY GALLOWS HIGH

Jacques Tourneur, 1947

Known in the US as *Out of the Past*, the movie *Build my Gallows High* captures the grand tragedy at the

heart of film noir. A private eye (Robert Mitchum) tries to escape his seedy past and start a new life with a decent girl, but he is haunted by a beautiful femme fatale (Jane Greer), with whom he may or may not be in love, and who may or may not be in love with him. They are tied together by fate, and, as she goes on the run for murder, their mutual destruction becomes all too inevitable.

THE RED SHOES

Michael Powell and Emeric Pressburger, 1948

Powell and Pressburger's *The Red Shoes* is both a glorious and seductive tribute to the ballet and a horror movie full of menace, as ballerina Victoria (Moira Shearer), is driven to despair by the ruthless and obsessive demands of an impresario, Lermontov (Anton Walbrook). The movie contains a story within a story: the 20-minute ballet sequence telling Hans Christian Andersen's tale of "The Red Shoes," in which a ballerina is danced to death by a pair of magic shoes, echoes the movie's main story.

See also: *A Matter of Life and Death* 86–87

ALL ABOUT EVE

Joseph L. Mankiewicz, 1950

Dark and bitingly witty, Joseph L. Mankiewicz's *All About Eve* is one of the bleakest movies ever made about show business. At its heart is a riveting performance by Bette Davis as the aging star Margo Channing, who is targeted by ambitious actress Eve Harrington (Anne Baxter). With a sob story that has

"everything but the bloodhounds snapping at her rear end," Eve worms her way into Margo's life and takes over her celebrity—but at a price, since she ends up in the power of manipulative theater critic Addison DeWitt. The movie also features a brief appearance by a young Marilyn Monroe.

LOS OLVIDADOS

Luis Buñuel, 1950

Also known as *The Young and the Damned*, *Los Olvidados* is Buñuel's retort to neorealist movies. Set in the slums of Mexico City, it is the story of two boys: El Jaibo, who escapes from prison; and Pedro, who is led astray by El Jaibo as he tracks down and kills the boy he thinks put him in jail. To this gritty scenario Buñuel adds his own brand of realism, including dreams, which for him were as much a part of life as pots and pans. He eschews a liberal social conscience for a confrontational approach that got the movie banned in Mexico for many years.

See also: *The Discreet Charm of the Bourgeoisie* 208–09

THE BIG HEAT

Fritz Lang, 1953

"Somebody's going to pay... because he forgot to kill me..." reads the tagline on the poster for Fritz Lang's taut film noir, scripted by crime reporter Sidney Boehm. Glenn Ford stars as an honest homicide detective who becomes caught up in a world of organized crime and police corruption. Gloria Grahame is the memorable femme fatale, a gangster's moll who turns against her boyfriend, brutally